

7/20/26

## Fisher Hill Association Annual Meeting – Recap

The FHA conducted its annual meeting on June 15th. For the 4th year in a row, we have held our annual meeting in the historic Ridgeview Congregational Church. Once again...I want to thank Roz Carnage and the leadership of the RCC for allowing the FHA to meet once again in the sanctuary of the Church.

Each year at our Annual meeting.... we have several tasks that we need to complete. Task #1 is signing up new members, updating the contact info of existing members and collecting membership fees. I want to thank those who volunteered to collect dues and sign up new members for the outstanding job they did staffing the sign-in table.

This year's guest speakers were Mayor Justin Brasch & Rob Hoch, Treasurer of the White Plains Historical Society. Mayor Brasch was one of the 3 Mayoral candidate guest speakers who joined us at last year's meeting. This year...after having won the election in November...he joined us as our Mayor.

With that.... I introduced the Mayor to the membership.

- The Mayor opened his remarks by saying that although he has served many years on the Common Council and been the Common Council President..."there is quite a lot to learn being Mayor". One of the biggest surprises was...the number of city-wide meetings, events, dinners, ribbon cutting ceremonies and conferences that the Mayor of White Plains is invited to and needs to attend.
- The City and School taxes will continue the long streak of being under the NY State Tax Cap. However, you may notice that the County Taxes (which are part of the overall taxes on your tax bill) have risen nearly 6%. (The Final 2026 Westchester County budget approved by the Board of Legislators reduced the initially proposed tax increase from 5.7% down to 3.7%)
- The City's Bond rating is AAA (Fitch)...which reflects strong financial resilience and responsible budgeting.
- The City is continuing to work with the Cappelli Organization to negotiate a final agreement to redevelop the Galleria Mall Property. Although, not yet set forth in writing.... the Cappelli Organization has agreed to increase the number of affordable units to a total of 800 @ 60% of AMI (adjusted mean income). The current White Plains "baseline" requirement for affordable housing is 12% which would yield 384 affordable units. Mayor Brasch went on to say that he anticipates finalizing the Galleria Mall redevelopment plan with the Cappelli Organization in the fall of 2026
- One of the many challenges the Mayor has had to address is building a team of City Commissions to lead the various City Departments. He was delighted to have recruited Wade Hardy as the City's new Public Safety Commissioner (leader over both the Police and Fire departments). Commissioner Hardy brings 39 years of experience in law enforcement and corporate security leadership to the job, including 22 years with the WPPD. He is the City's first African American Public Safety Commissioner. The Mayor is also delighted to have Karen Pasquale join his administration as his Chief of Staff. Chief of Staff Pasquale had previously worked for Mayor Roach as senior advisor. Most recently, Chief of Staff Pasquale has worked at the County level as Assistant Director of Operations in Ken Jenkins administration.

- The Mayor explained that all of the City owned & operated public garages have been inspected and are safe. That said...the estimated cost of structural repairs at the underground parking facility at the City Library has grown from \$2-3 million to nearly \$10 million. All of the City's public garages are now undergoing engineering evaluations to determine the cost of required repairs.

The Mayor took questions from the Fisher Hill membership.

- The Mayor was asked about alleged illegal housing and parking on Walton Ave and Wallace Place. The Mayor explained that he was not familiar with the specific addresses of where illegal housing or parking may be taking place. He suggested that the resident contact the Building Dept. & Code Enforcement.
- The Mayor was asked when construction would take place at the "Hole in the Ground" at the corner of South Broadway and Maple Ave. The Mayor responded by saying, "the City does not own the property and is not the Developer of the property...so, I cannot tell you when construction may start." The Questioner replied to the Mayor shouting back, "you are the Mayor....it is a disgrace that the "Hole in the Ground" has been there for over 6 years! What are you doing about it!" The Mayor explained, "the property was previously owned by the Toll Brothers. They were the developer that removed the buildings and excavated the site for foundations and then stopped the project. Recently, a White Plains developer purchased the property from Toll Brothers and that developer is currently studying how best to re-develop the property. At this time, no plans for the redevelopment of the property have been presented to the City. The City cannot force a property owner to move forward with a proposed project. As long as the owner is not breaking the law and is paying the property taxes...the Developer of the property has done nothing wrong. I am sorry, but I have to move on." At that point, the questioner stood up and shouted at the Mayor, "if you were at a meeting in Rosedale or Gedney Farm you'd spend an hour talking to us!" With both the questioner and the Mayor shouting at one and other...and the Mayor's security aid moving towards the Questioner, I stood up and asked the Questioner "to stop shouting at the Mayor...and sit down!" The Questioner then shouted back at me, "you have talked too much. I don't want to hear from you!" I repeated my instructions for the Questioner to cease yelling at the Mayor and to sit down."
- Mayor Brasch took several more questions from the membership. He responded to the Questioners by asking that they contact the City's Commissioners and their departments with their specific concerns or issues.

With the Mayor's remarks completed.... I introduced the Robert Hoch, Treasurer of the White Plains Historical Society, to the membership. I had asked Mr. Hoch to share with the membership the history of Fisher Hill.

Mr. Hoch's recap of the Fisher Hill "history" was as follows:

- The area that Fisher Hill is located was inhabited by the Weckquaeskeck people. Archeological evidence of Weckquaeskeck people living in the area dates back to approximately 1000AD.
- The Weckquaeskeck people called the area we call White Plains...Quarropas. Quarropas refers to the "white marshes" in the area or "white mist" which hovered above the wetlands in the area.
- In November 1683 a group of English puritans from Rye and Connecticut met with the Weckquaeskeck and purchased 4,400 acres of land from the Weckquaeskeck. Those 4,400 acres became the settlement that was called "White Plains" ...the name being derived from "Quarropas".

- On July 11<sup>th</sup>, 1776, the Declaration of Independence was first read in New York on the courthouse steps in White Plains.... giving birth to the State of New York.
- In the summer of 1776, British General Howe began a campaign in and around New York City...first in Staten Island and then in Long Island. Washington's forces were defeated in the Battle of Long Island. Washington retreated to Harlem Heights in Manhattan and then to White Plains on October 21<sup>st</sup>, 1776. Howe's troops moved from camp in New Rochelle towards White Plains to engage Washington. Washington established his headquarters at Elijah Miller's house in North White Plains. Elijah Miller's wife was Ann Fisher...who was the daughter of Johannis (John) Fisher.
- Washington's forces were deployed over 3 miles from Chatterton's Hill (Battle Hill) to Purdy's Hill and across Broadway to the northeast. British forces were deployed on the eastern side of the Bronx River from the Scarsdale border northward thru Fisher Hill and along the York Road (today's Post Road). British/Hessian artillery (cannons) positioned on Fisher Hill fired on Washington's troops on Chatterton's Hill and Purdy's Hill.
- The Battle of White Plains began in earnest on 10/28/1776. On October 31<sup>st</sup>, Washington ordered his troops to make a disciplined retreat to the hills to the north. On 11/5/1776, British Commander Howe turned his army south to complete the removal of Continental troops from Manhattan.
- The first "Fisher" to live in the area was William Fisher, who was born in England. He married Adriana Wynant Vander Burg (Dutch colonialist) in 1693. Their son Johannis (John) Wynant Fisher born on 12/10/1704 in White Plains. Johannis (John) and his wife Sarah Williams were the parents of 3 daughters and 2 sons (Nicholas & Elijah) who survived into adulthood. John built the Fisher Homestead on Orchard St. adjacent to what is now I-287. Nicholas Fisher and his wife had 1 daughter. Elijah Fisher (d. 1815) and his wife had 2 daughters and 1 son...John Fisher. John Fisher was born in 1775 and died in 1856. Myndert Fisher was a large landowner/farmer in White Plains in the 19<sup>th</sup> century...he owned all the land bounded on the east by Winchester St. on the North by Martine Ave and the railroad, on the south by Post Rd. and on the West by Tibbits Ave in the 19<sup>th</sup> century. Fisher Ave, Fisher Court and Fisher Hill were likely named after Myndert Fisher. Myndert Fisher died in 1885.
- Train service began from Manhattan to White Plains in 1844. The introduction of rail service cut the trip to Manhattan from an "all day" trip via coach to a 2 hour "commute". The rail connection allowed for wealthy Manhattanites to escape to their "weekend country estates" and it opened up the possibility of living in White Plains and commuting to Manhattan for work. The introduction of the railroad began the transformation of White Plains from a sleepy village surrounded by farmland to the City we know today.
- Fisher Hill's residential development began in earnest in the 1900's. Photos of the construction of the Ridgeview Congregational Church (RCC) in 1900 show that Midland and Ridgeview Avenues were unpaved dirt roads with no visible homes. A 1906 photo of the RCC shows both Midland and Ridgeview Avenues are both paved and that Ridgeview Ave has been substantially built out with homes present on both sides of the street.
- In 1884 the City of New York acquired much of the land for the Bronx Park...which by 1897 had become the Bronx Zoo and Botanical Garden. In 1895 the Bronx Parkway Commission (BPC) began reviewing the possibilities of developing a road and scenic area along the Bronx River. The primary reason the BPC was brought into existence was the fact that the Bronx river from the

Kenisco Reservoir to the Bronx Park (15 miles south) was a heavily polluted waterway filled with human, animal & factory waste...along with refuse of every kind. The river was a public health hazard and there was a fear that the fetid and polluted river would harm or kill the Bronx Zoo's animals.

- Over the next 20 years the BPC purchased land adjacent to the Bronx River to create a 15-mile-long park-way. It worked with municipalities to prevent sewerage from polluting the river and convinced factory owners to relocate their operations away from the waterway. In July of 1925 the 15-mile Bronx River Parkway (the roadway) was official opened...30 years after it was first proposed. With railroad service and an automobile parkway stretching from NYC to White Plains...the city saw dramatic growth and development in the 20<sup>th</sup> century.

Mr. Hoch took several questions from the membership and concluded his remarks. I thanked Mr. Hoch for attending our meeting and for his presentation.

#### White Plains Stats:

The first census in the United States was conducted in 1790. The population of White Plains in 1790 was 505...40 of which were slaves. The 1800 population was 575. 26 years after the arrival of the railroad the population in 1870 was 2,630 and by 1890 it was 4,508. In 1930 after the Bronx River Parkway had been completed and in operation...the population was 35,800...in 1940 it was 40,100. Today the population is approximately 60,000. The day-time population of White Plains swells to approximately 250,000. Today, the population of Fisher Hill is approximately 4,000. The Fisher Hill neighborhood is notably diverse in ethnicity, age and income. (stats researched by Dalton)

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For the past 3 or 4 years I have invited Police Chief Joseph Castelli to attend our meeting and share with the membership crime statistics for the City and specifically for the Fisher Hill neighborhood. Chief Castelli was promoted by Mayor Brasch in January to be the Deputy Commissioner of Public Safety...with Public Safety Commissioner Wade Hardy.

I asked Deputy Commissioner Castelli if it was possible for him to share with me the crime stats for Fisher Hill and the City from 2025 -2026 and also for the first 5 months of 2026. A few days later D.C. Castelli forwarded me the crime stats for Fisher Hill and the City.

In the past when Chief Castelli presented these stats at our annual meetings.... he always emphasized that while Fisher Hill does have "some" crime....it is really a very safe, low crime neighborhood. When he sent me the current stats...he repeated, "Fisher Hill is a very safe, low crime neighborhood."

- From January 2026 to the end of May 2026...Fisher Hill had the following crime stats
  - 1 aggravated assault (a felony) against a person – with an arrest
  - 1 robbery against a person
  - 1 burglary – entered a building with an intent to commit a crime
  - 10 larcenies – theft of property
  - 3 assaults (a misdemeanor) against a person
  - 4 criminal mischiefs
  - No hate crimes
- In all of 2025...Fisher Hill had the following crime stats:

- 1 aggravated assault (a felony) against a person – with an arrest
  - 1 homicide – active case
  - 1 robbery – with an arrest
  - 4 burglaries – 2 commercial & 2 residential
  - 15 larcenies – theft of property
  - 15 other crimes – assaults & criminal mischiefs
  - No hate crimes
- From January 2026 to the end of May 2026...the City had the following crime stats:
    - 89% of all crimes in the City were larcenies (thefts)...a 4% increase over the same period in 2025
  - In all of 2025...the City had the following crime stats:
    - 86% of all crimes in the City were larcenies (thefts)....50% of which were shoplifting. The overall incidents of crime dropped 17% from 2024.
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I presented the “prototype” of a Fisher Hill Association website to the membership. I also passed out copies of a QR code to the membership which allowed members to scan the code and then view the “prototype” FHA website on their smartphones. The website will have the following webpages:

- Home page – with a “birds-eye” 3D view of Fisher Hill and the City which allows viewers to “fly thru” the neighborhood and City.
  - Neighborhood Post page – allowing Fisher Hill residents to post on the page - events, civic notices, volunteer opportunities, tag sales, etc.
  - Events page – a curated list of events going on in White Plains & Fisher Hill over the next several months.
  - Agenda page – an archive of Fisher Hill Association annual meeting recaps, board meetings and Mayor’s office meetings.
  - About page – a brief history of the Fisher Hill neighborhood
  - Join the FHA page – How to join the Fisher Hill Association
  - Contact page – how to contact the President of the FHA
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I raised the topic of “was the FHA membership interested in sponsoring community-wide events in Fisher Hill”. I mentioned an email that I sent the membership several months earlier when I asked, “would you like to see the Fisher Hill Association sponsor community events...like...a block party, a neighborhood cleanup or a musical event?” I received 3 responses from that email...that went out to 100 members...not a strong level of interest.

About 4 years ago, I asked the leadership of the Ridgeview Congregational Church (RCC) if the FHA could hold its annual meeting in the sanctuary of the church. Why did I make that request? Because I recognized that the RCC had served as an anchor of the Fisher Hill neighborhood for over 125 years. The RCC was the first new structure built in Fisher Hill in 1901 because the property owners developing the neighborhood recognized building a church would not only serve the spiritual needs of this new community but as the center of community activities for the new neighborhood. The members of this church held countless fund raisers for scholarships, Halloween, Christmas & Easter parties for the children of the neighborhood and Chef Surprise lunches in this building for over 100 years.

I think there is a great opportunity before the FHA...the opportunity to breathe new life into this building. To their credit.... the leaders of the RCC have battled and overcome many challenges over the past 10-15

years. I suggest it is time for the Fisher Hill Association to partner with the RCC to make this historic building the community center of our neighborhood once again.

With all that said, “is there anyone here who would like to see the FHA sponsor community-wide events?” Two hands shot up. The first...was a woman right in front of me. She said she would be happy to support more community events in Fisher Hill. The second hand was raised by Rebecca Engelmann...who said, “I would like to organize a Fisher Hill block party.” To which I responded, “terrific...Rebecca you are in charge of organizing the block party.” Rebecca circulated a sign-up sheet for those interested in supporting or helping organize the block party...and 15 people in the audience signed up.

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The final business of the meeting was the Election of Officers and Board Members. In the month prior to the annual meeting, I sent out an email to the membership inviting anyone who would like to stand for election as an Officer or Board Member position to contact Jane Prout (the Election Manager). Earlier this year, Joanne Delanoy moved from Fisher Hill. Joanne had served as the FHA Treasurer for well over 10 years. I asked Board Member, Joanne McLaughlin to stand for election as the new Treasurer of the FHA. She agreed to do so...and I asked her to notify Jane Prout...to let her know that she would stand for election as the new FHA Treasurer. In addition, Jane contacted all of the other current FHA officers and Board Members and asked if they would stand for another 1-year term. Prior to our annual meeting...Jane reported that she had not received any requests to stand for an Officer or Board Member position from the FHA membership. Jane also reported Joanne McLaughlin would stand for election as Treasurer and all of the existing Officers and Board Members agreed to stand for election to another 1-year term. I “motioned” to nominate the slate of candidates for this year’s election by reading out the names of the existing Officers and Board Members along with Joanne McLaughlin’s name for Treasurer. I asked for “a second” to my “motion”. The “motion” was “seconded”. I asked for a voice vote of the slate of candidates, “aye” would indicate a “yes” vote, “nay” would indicate and “no” vote. The voice vote was overwhelmingly “ayes”. There were no “nay” votes. The slate of candidates was elected to serve another 1-year term.

#### Officers

- Michael Dalton – President – 914 497 7236
- Jonna Robins – Vice President – 917 576 0882
- Joanne McLaughlin – Treasurer – 914 497 3628
- Secretary –

#### Board Members

- Sandra Adams – 914 588 5795
- Cherly Daughtery – 914 262 4985
- Ayanna Faulkner – 914 438 1703
- Rod Garner – 914 612 3145
- Olga Klimek – 914 948 7977
- Anthony Kuhn – 914 713 4554
- Wayne McCants
- Matt O’Sullivan – 914 602 2361
- Jane Prout – 914 946 1420
- Aleta Rice – 914 980 8043
- Tania Saiz – 914 393 1702
- Howard & Lea Waldman – 914 949 7368

Michael Dalton – President  
Fisher Hill Association  
914 497 7236